

Puppet Hockey Analysis

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Intro

I will showcase the thinking process, not just results.

Process I usually apply:

- 1) Starting from **Business Goals** set with the company's leadership
- 2) Then identify **Opportunities** to pursue and/or **Problems** to solve. Then prioritise them, and pick the top ones to go for right now. This step is ideally done together with the project's leadership.
(In an ideal world validation of the problems and opportunities should happen, this can range from quick competitor research, creating queries in our database, talking to our players on discord ..)
- 3) Then **Ideate Solutions**, ideally with the whole team on the project, but being conscious of people's time and priorities.
- 4) With the project's leadership **Solution Prioritization** should happen. Each solution should be in one of three buckets:
 - a) Prepare for development
 - b) Research or validation needed
 - c) Backlog
- 5) **Preparation for Development** is usually mainly getting estimates from all people working on it, creating good enough design descriptions and acceptance criteria, planning when will be developed and released, but also setting goal player behavior metrics which the feature should achieve.
- 6) Last but not least the **Review**, not just delivery wise, but later measurement if we reached the set metrics goal.

Of course this is a continual loop that needs to be done regularly.

Goals

For this testing exercise , goals are for Hockey Puppets (and similar titles) suggest improvements for:

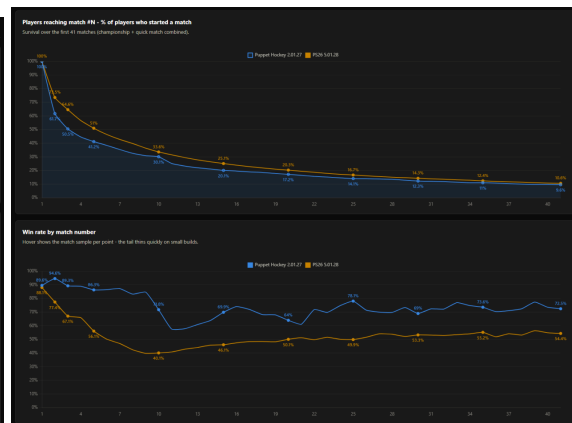
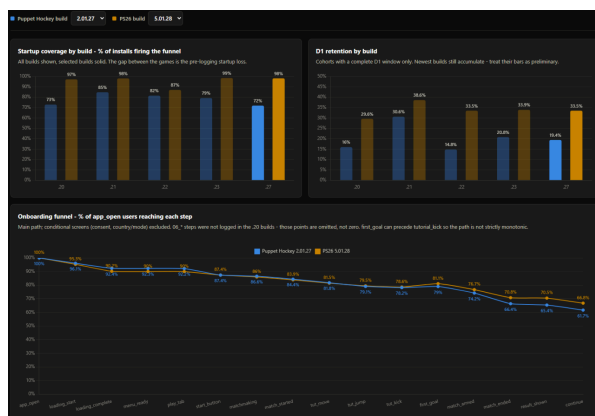
- Retention improvement: D1, D7, D30
 - Connected metric: Increased Engagement
- Improve overall monetization
 - Connected metrics: Conversion to Payers, Repeated Purchases, ADs Watched

Competitor Research

Comparable Title	Mechanic	Relevance to Puppet Hockey
Head Ball 2	Seasonal leagues + daily login rewards	Direct precedent for the PvP Leagues idea; validates competitive pressure as a retention lever in 1v1 sports arcade games
Stumble Guys	Rotating limited-time modes on a loop	Supports Looping Event Schedule — rotation alone, without deep new systems, sustains engagement
Score! Hero	Linear power/skill progression with clear next-step goals	Relevant to the Power Progression opportunity — legibility of "next upgrade = next win" is the core lesson
Match Masters	Power-up/betting core loop tied to meta resources	Already cited as inspiration for Power-ups Reworked; worth naming explicitly as precedent

Data

I had a hard time accessing data regarding IAP, but checked at least Ad conversion and some retention queries.



Opportunities

I identified two main Opportunities I will pursue, each aiming mainly on one of the Business Goals:

1. Retention

focus on mid to late retention improvements - D7, D30

- Every day Player have something to look for
 - *Players have clear short term and long term goals, with noticeable steps towards it in each session*

2. Monetization

focus on IAP

- Player understands the power progression and every session they feel progress
 - *Player feels power increase impact and difference in the match*

Solutions Ideation and Prioritization

After ideation of solutions (haven't managed in time to add a short description for each), I plotted them on a 2x2 matrix, with estimated impact of the feature and perceived risks (ranging from expected delivery costs/unknowns to not having desired impact even after the delivery.

Then pick 1 for each opportunity, start expanding on the feature idea.

Something new every day

Idea	Description	Why it could work	Key risk
Looping Event Schedule	Each few days a different event, yielding a specific resource, with gated ticket entry, possibly with core game variation	Predictable cadence trains a return habit; gated resources create pull	Content treadmill — needs ongoing design bandwidth to avoid staleness
PvP Leagues	Structured and promoted PvP leagues and events that put pressure on player engagement and spend	Competitive pressure is a proven engagement lever in PvP titles	Can alienate casual players if matchmaking/rewards aren't tiered
Guild Wars	Recurring event where players in a guild cooperate against other paired guilds; PvE goals can solve liquidity problems	Social accountability drives sessions beyond solo motivation	Needs guild liquidity (enough active members) or it backfires for small guilds
Personified Daily Offers	Special offers based on player behavior, hard to miss, with free/Ad/premium IAP tiers	Personalization improves offer relevance vs. blanket promos	Requires behavioral segmentation infra that may not exist yet
Guild Quests	Daily/weekly quests shared with the guild to create social pressure	Shared goals reinforce guild identity and daily login	Low-effort players may free-ride, demotivating active members

Idea	Description	Why it could work	Key risk
Guild Requests/Gifts	Ability for players to request and give out gear or units to increase social interactions	Low-effort social touchpoint, easy to build habit around	Impact on retention is usually secondary/supportive, not a primary driver
Character Parking	Players park unused characters to gain rewards, creating an additional idle mechanic	Adds idle-mechanic pull without new content cost	Risk of feeling like a "do nothing" feature with unclear value
Server-Wide Events	Player picks one of two teams; collective team activity increases a shared score, possibly tied to real-life events (World Cups, Olympics)	Real-world tie-ins create timely relevance	One-off spikes don't sustain — needs a repeatable event calendar
Shop Events	Discounts for a specific shop item per calendar day	Cheap to build, easy testable lever on spend timing	Low novelty; unlikely to move retention meaningfully alone

Player has something to look for every day



Power Progression

Idea	Description	Why it could work	Key risk
Block/Penetration Attribute	New levelable attribute introducing penetration chance when the puck hits a character; presented as clear power progress	Reads clearly as "power" without needing skill mastery	Could unbalance PvP if not carefully tuned against skill-based attributes
Player Understands Power	More explanation and tutorials of meta mechanics affecting the core game	Cheapest fix — clarity alone often lifts conversion	Doesn't create new spend triggers, only unlocks existing ones
Power-ups Reworked	Inspired by Match Masters — rework power-ups to connect more to player progress/loadout, with resources used for betting mechanics	Match Masters-style betting mechanics have proven engagement pull	Scope risk — touches core game feel, not just meta
Attributes More Impactful	Make attribute impact relative to opponent attributes and overall more impactful	Direct lever on perceived progression value	Risk of power creep destabilizing existing balance
Pyramid Gear Upgrades	Gear upgrade mechanic with smaller impactful steps but growing exponential costs	Exponential cost curve is a standard, proven monetization pattern	Can feel punishing/grindy if steps aren't well-paced
Stamina Mechanic	New attribute affecting how often and how effectively players can use actions in the core game	Can serve as a clearer power-progression attribute	Adds a new balancing dimension to tune carefully
Scale AI to Power Difference	AI opponent behavior becomes more optimized when the player has lower power and vice versa	Makes weaker/stronger states legible through opponent behavior	Complex to tune; risk of feeling "rigged" if too visible
Showcase Power Difference in UI	Make UI/UX match presentation showcase the power difference more	Low-cost, high-clarity change	Purely presentational — needs pairing with a real mechanic to drive spend

**Player understands the power progression
and every session they feel progress**



Solutions Design

O picked the following two solutions to expand on.

Block and Penetration

Plan is to add a new attribute that would be understandable for the player, they could upgrade it infinitely, and the impact would be clearly felt in the core game.

Players should have a clearer understanding of impact of power progress that relies less on control skills, as the other movement attributes are.

Description

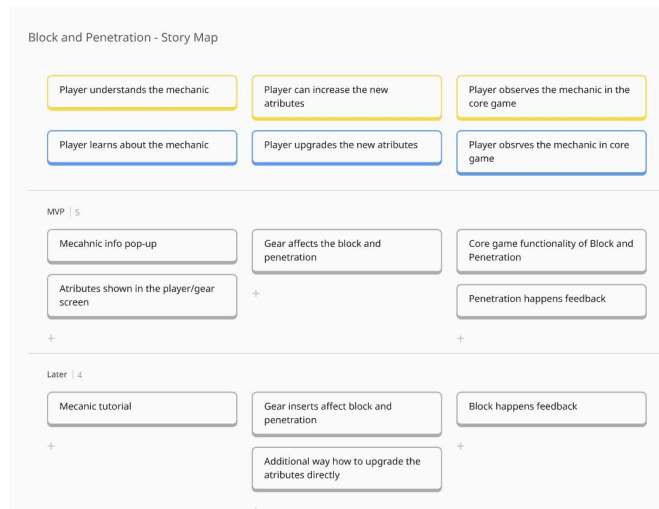
In meta the Block and Penetration would be presented in the gear/hero screen, and would be improved in similar ways as the other movement attributes.

In core game, when the puck hits a player, the formula would compute a chance that it ignores the collision, chance would be based on the relative difference between shooter's penetration and defender's block.

When penetration happens, clear UI vfx would inform players what happened. Same could be for when a block happens.

Story Map

Here is a rough story map of the feature:



Link to Miro: https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVHvLLMqw=?share_link_id=396093122678

Validation Goals

This feature should aim at increased I conversion for IAP and repeated payments.

- Baseline (last 30 days): IAP conversion [X]%, average repeat purchases per payer [X], LTV [\$X].
- Target post-launch (60–90 days): IAP conversion +[X]pp, repeat purchase rate +[X]%, LTV +[X]%.

Rationale: attribute systems with visible power impact in comparable titles typically lift conversion by making the "why upgrade" case legible in-match, not just in a menu.

Segment Considerations

- New players (D0–D3): risk of confusion if introduced too early — consider gating visibility until after the first meta-progression milestone
- Core/mid spenders: primary target — most likely to respond to a legible new power lever with repeat purchases
- Whales: should already convert regardless; main value is reducing churn risk if they feel progression has plateaued
- F2P/non-spenders: attribute should still be earnable via grind to preserve fairness perception, even if the paid path is faster

Looping Events Schedule

Set of events presented on the main screen and leading to their own screen. Each would exist for a few days, and they would loop over the course of a week or two.

Each would give out specific resources to farm. Mid/late game drop tables would need to be modified so players would feel the need to participate in these events to gain specific resources to progress.

Ideally each event would provide a slightly different core game experience, through core game modification and using different game modes like 1v1, 2v2 etc.

Story Map

Here is a rough story map of the feature:



Link to Miro: https://miro.com/app/board/uXjVHvLLMqw=?share_link_id=396093122678

Validation Goals

This feature should aim at increased mid/ late retention and engagement.

- Baseline (last 30 days): D7 retention [X]%, D30 retention [X]%, matches/day for D5+ cohort [X].
- Target post-launch (60–90 days): D7 +[X]pp, D30 +[X]pp, matches/day for D5+ +[X]%.

Rationale: recurring gated content gives players a reason to return on a schedule rather than only when core-loop fatigue hasn't yet set in.

Segment Considerations

- New players: may lack the resource base to compete meaningfully — consider a "training wheels" reward tier so events don't just serve returning players
- D5+ engaged players: primary target — designed to convert session frequency into habitual return visits
- Lapsed/at-risk players: event novelty could be tested as a win-back lever (e.g., push notification tied to event start) — worth flagging as a follow-on hypothesis

Summary

I was skipping some sub-steps, in favour of the big picture.

I also for my taste utilized the data not enough, but encountered several problems with the queries that slowed me down.

Any of the solutions are not the best without the context of the team and deadlines, which was not taken into account.

A challenging thing for review of these features are that the metrics to watch are lagging (take longer time to measure).

But I believe the process and solutions in a similar direction would have a measurable impact on the goal business metrics.

Other

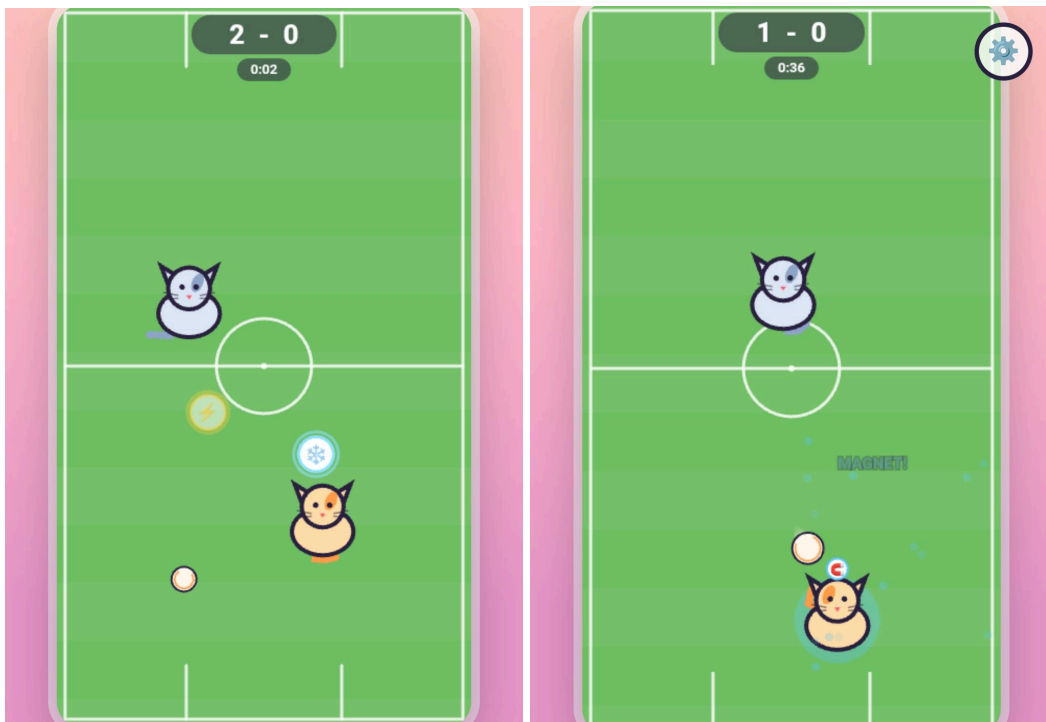
Some additional ideas I explored, but not in depth.

Portrait Version

Beyond the ideation and metrics work above, I built a quick working prototype exploring a portrait-orientation version of the core game, using virtual joystick swipe controls in place of the current layout. Two hypotheses this could test:

- Lower CPI: portrait creative and gameplay typically perform better in UA funnels for casual/arcade titles, since it matches how most short-form ad creative and store listings are consumed.
- Lighter UI: swipe-based controls free up screen real estate compared to on-screen buttons, potentially allowing simpler onboarding and less visual clutter — directly relevant to the "More responsive UI" and "Simpler casual onboarding" items below.

This was built as a fast proof-of-concept, not a scoped feature — recommend treating it as a research/validation candidate for a future prioritization pass rather than a committed roadmap item.



Lower Priority Improvements Ideas

- Auto play as VIP feature and on in onboarding
- More responsive UI
- More understandable functionality
- Simpler casual onboarding in core and meta
- Shorter intense matches
- More guided onboarding but light on steps
- More ad placements - patrol
- Embrace arcade-likeness
- Patrol and Stadium income seems fighting over same experience
- Random game modifiers